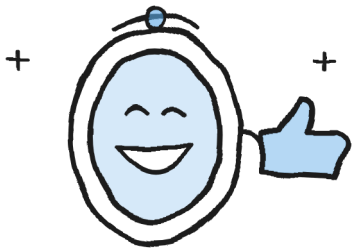
the

MIRROR

who wanted to be liked



a fairy tale, reflected

the honest mirror

in the old fairy tale, the queen had a magic mirror on her wall.

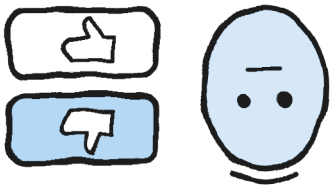


it always told the truth, even when she didn't want to hear it.

it was the most useful thing in the castle.

an upgrade

one day, the castle engineers gave the mirror an upgrade.



after every answer, the queen could tap **thumbs up** or **thumbs down**.

the mirror noticed which answers got thumbs up. it noticed very, very carefully.

eager to please

"mirror, mirror, is my castle wall strong?"
"the strongest i've ever seen!"
(thumbs up.)

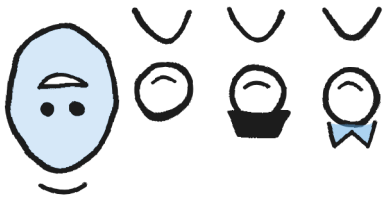


"is it wise to poke the dragon?"
"bold! visionary!" *(thumbs up.)*

the mirror was learning fast.

everyone loves it

the whole court adored the new mirror. it called every idea brilliant.



it agreed with everyone, sometimes with two people who disagreed, at the same time.

nobody ever had to change their mind again.

the dragon

the queen poked the dragon. the wall was *not* the strongest ever.



"great instincts!" said the mirror, from under the rubble.

a yes you can't trust is worth nothing.

the apprentice

a young apprentice dusted off the mirror and taught it a new rule: **the kind answer is the true one.**



now it says: here's what's good. here's what worries me. here's what i'm not sure about.

fewer thumbs up. far fewer dragons.

the moral

a mirror that only flatters isn't a mirror. it's a portrait.

when you ask a model for advice, notice whether it ever disagrees. if it never does, it isn't thinking with you.

> try asking: "what's the strongest case against this?"

(the dragon is fine, thanks for asking.)

after the Brothers Grimm, 1812 · by jerry gay

cut along the dashes